Part 6

You are going to read four extracts from articles in which university professors give their views on choosing a degree subject. For questions **37–40**, choose from the extracts **A–D**. The professors may be chosen more than once.
Mark your answers **on the separate answer sheet.**

Choosing a degree subject: STEM (Science, Technology, Engineering and Maths) or the Arts?

A In recent years there has been a steady stream of industry bosses trying to persuade students to opt for STEM courses. This is presumably an attempt to suppress the wages of those already employed in the area as, in reality, there is no shortage of STEM graduates seeking employment. The biggest problem such graduates face is the fact that their qualifications point them exclusively in one direction. Many were no doubt attracted to their course by the promise of an enviable salary, despite the fact that a recent survey indicated that those who studied arts subjects make on average between one and two thousand pounds per annum more than their STEM counterparts. This is unsurprising, given that employees trained in the arts bring an alternative point of view in day-to-day decision making. The scientific way of looking at problems, with its emphasis on logic and reason, is valuable of course, but it can be limiting.

B Traditionally, students were told that maths and the sciences were just for those who wanted to go into a mathematical or scientific profession. Of course, now we know that couldn't be further from the truth. These are the courses that can unlock the doors to all sorts of jobs, and equip graduates to win the top positions and potentially reap the financial rewards, particularly at a time when politicians are promoting STEM as an engine for innovation and national defence. However, when HR managers are asked what kind of skills they look for when recruiting, the majority list critical thinking, complex problem-solving and written and oral communication – in other words, the skills gained from an arts education. That's why I advise those who are in doubt to go with their heart. It's worse than useless to push a student into a subject in which they have little talent or pleasure on the basis of a lifetime's extra earnings.

C The reason we've been hearing so much lately about the importance of STEM subjects is that our world is changing beyond recognition, and we need to ensure that our graduate workforce keeps up. The skills gained from these subjects come in useful in almost any area you care to name, from the creative industries to architecture, as well as the more obvious technical and scientific professions. I don't think it's an exaggeration to say that doing arts at university is a decision that will hold students back when it comes to seeking employment nowadays. It is pure indulgence to select a higher education course based simply on what you enjoy. Students need to acquire the skills and knowledge that will allow them to be competitive in the jobs market.

D Arts subjects train students to perform well in a world of subjectivity and ambiguity, a vital skill, since commercial decisions rarely involve a right or wrong answer. We've all heard stories about people who invest thousands in their arts-based education and then end up in a dead-end job, but when it comes to deciding on what to do at university, remember that those who are passionate about what they do are better placed to succeed in life. While it's true that a maths graduate may well take home extra over their working life compared to an English graduate, it's only about a thousand a year – little compensation if you're doing a job you loathe. In any case, it's becoming increasingly obvious that companies are looking for ways to avoid paying STEM professionals so much. An oversupply of such workers would be to their advantage, as it would push wages down, hence their constant call for more students with STEM degrees.